

PREMISE DELTA v0.3 (THE TRUSTING FORGERY): FABLE ATTACK • 2026-09-08

Fresh Fable agent, given only four-keys-premise-delta-trusting-forgery-v0.3-2026-09-08.md and its own six-front prompt. Filed verbatim. GPT's independent attack on the same text goes beside it when Stephen runs it; the disposition follows; Stephen rules. Verdict: REWORK, high confidence.

Adversarial review of premise delta v0.3, the trusting forgery

Reviewer: Claude (Fable). Independent of ChatGPT. Read: the delta only.

Front 1. Violet's engine

Strongest objection. The delta makes Violet the best judge of a hand on the coast and then has her look at a gilded panel in her own alphabet, better than she can do it, and write "it isn't any of you four, and I'd know" with a pupil of seven years in the room of candidates. Nobody in town knows Brad can gild, but Violet does; she taught him. A panel in her alphabet has exactly two possible hands in the world, hers and the one she trained, and she rules out the second without a sentence. The delta needs her expertise to be absolute for the letters (Brad must sit a whole day with the debt book to get her cursive) and absent for the panel. The same woman cannot be both.

The teacher's pride does not repair this, it inverts. She carries the panel to two rival signwriters, the people whose opinion a professional's pride actually fears, and they tell her "yours, in a very good year." After that verdict, showing the pupil is not a confession that his teacher cannot account for her work; the trade has just certified it as her best. What is left of "pride" after two peers have said yours is not pride, it is the plot needing her not to ask the one gilder she knows. The machinery (padlock, four keys, solicitor, funeral-posted notes) is then built by a woman who has removed the single obvious question from her own investigation.

Second objection, held in reserve: the tin. If she believed her tobacco was being tampered with enough to lodge a letter for after her funeral, she either stopped smoking from that tin, in which case the machinery is out of scale to a threat she has removed, or she kept smoking it, in which case "I might be imagining it" is not plain doubt but a woman choosing not to know, and the delta wants the reader to take it as the former.

Severity. Serious, at the edge of fatal for her characterisation.

What would have to be true. Either Brad's gilding is demonstrably not her alphabet and she has never seen him attempt it (which cuts against "pupil of seven years"), or the true letter shows she did weigh him and states why she set him aside, which means she suspected for at least a second and the delta's "not for a second" goes. And the pride reason has to survive the sequence as written: she asks the trade first, then declines the pupil; the delta needs a reason that is stronger after the trade has answered, not weaker.

Front 2. The room on the Monday night and the three weeks after

Strongest objection. The question asked that night that the delta has not answered is Ruby's: "Why did Vi think she was going to die?" Four people are holding a letter delivered by a solicitor after a funeral, from a store re-padded with the only four keys cut for the purpose. That is a woman who expected to be killed. The forged letter's content is a shelf, a back bedroom and a doubt. Brad cut the one thing that explains the scale of the machinery, the tin, and in cutting it he left the machinery standing with nothing under it. The gap between "she lodged letters with a solicitor" and "over a shelf" is audible on Day 14 to anyone in the room, and the delta has the room feel relief. Relief lasts until the first person says "you don't lodge letters with a solicitor over a shelf."

Compounding it, a drafting fault: the forged ban reads "over a shelf and a loose lid," while section 3 says Brad cut the tin. The lid is the tin. Either the phrase goes or Ruby, a nurse, asks "what lid?" on night one and the letter has referred to something it never explains.

On the three weeks: the delta gives Brad the job of defending Liam and gives Liam no line. A man who has read, in the dead woman's own hand, that it is not him, and who is being convicted by the room that read it with him, says the obvious thing: "She wrote it wasn't me. You all read it." The delta's only answer is Ruby's "Vi didn't write down things that didn't bother her," which is an answer to a different question. The room does not fail to notice it is doing the opposite of what she wrote; the delta simply does not write the moment where Liam makes them notice, and that moment is unavoidable.

Severity. Serious.

What would have to be true. The forged letter has to carry a reason, in her voice, for the scale of the machinery that is not the tin and does not send a nurse to the police; and the room has to have a spoken line that overrides her clearance of Liam. The second exists in the story's own logic ("she thought she'd know, and she's dead") but it is v8.1's turn moved into the room's mouths in week three, and if that is where it lives the delta should say so. And "a loose lid" must be removed from the forgery or the tin restored to it.

Front 3. Margo

Strongest objection. The delta calls Margo's turn a reading. It is not a reading, it is a document in her own filing cabinet from Day -120, in Violet's hand, naming Brad and the sum. The delta's own chapter 7 turn (the letter asks for everything odd and omits the debts) is available to Margo, with the paperwork, on the night of Day 14. By Day 8 she knows the book of everything is gone from a house locked front and back. By Day 14 she knows the letter is silent on the calling-in she witnessed. By Day 19, meeting one, she knows the debtor said nothing at a table convened to list everything odd. Every element of ruling 2 is in her hands by Day 19. The delta has her open the file on Day 51. Thirty-two days pass in which an accountant, whose trade is omissions, does not notice one she personally has the counter-document for, and nothing arrives in those thirty-two days that she did not already hold.

Earliest competent action: Day 8, recipient Del, not the sister. "Her record of who owed her money is missing from a locked house." That is a theft of financial records reported by the deceased's accountant, six days before any letter exists, and Del's first question is "who owed her," and client confidence is much thinner against a stolen record than against a private reading. Failing that: Day 15, recipient Brad, alone. "Vi called you in for the van money. Is it going on your list?" Either answer starts Brad's clock on Margo six weeks early and Day 60 becomes Day 20.

On dying on it: the delta gives no mechanism from the reading to her death, so it cannot be tested here, only noted as unsupported.

Severity. Serious.

What would have to be true. Something Margo lacks on Day 19 and gains on Day 51, named. The one candidate the delta half-supplies (she reads Violet's silence about the debts as Violet keeping Brad's confidence, in character for Violet) explains Day 14 but not Day 19, because Brad's own silence at the table is the thing that breaks that reading and it happens at meeting one. And a reason she tells the sister, and not Del, that the book is gone.

Front 4. Chapter 7

Strongest objection. The omission is an inference, and the delta's own rulings supply the counter-inference. The forged letter presents its list as "a starter list, to show you what I mean." By its own words it does not claim to contain everything odd; it claims to be examples. So the absence of the panel and the debts is a partial list being partial, not a contradiction between a document and the world. Ally's turn then rests on "she would have put those in," which is exactly the kind of character reading that convicted Liam at Ruby's table.

Worse, the delta pre-rebuts its own turn. Ruling 7 says Violet was too proud to show the four the panel while alive. Ruling 2 says only Brad and Margo knew of the debts, because Violet kept Brad's confidence. So the delta has already given Violet an innocent, in-character reason to leave each of the two things out of a letter to the four. Ally in chapter 7 must argue that a woman too proud to show them the panel living would write it to them dead. That is arguable. It is not a turn on a fact.

There is also an internal contradiction: ruling 4 says both omitted things are "known to the town"; ruling 2 says only Brad and Margo know the debts were called in. If ruling 2 is right, Ally's route to the debts runs through a dead accountant's client file, and the delta does not say who hands it to her or why. If ruling 4 is right, Ruby knew about the debts on Day 14 and Margo's lock is not load-bearing.

Could Ruby or Liam have seen it Monday night? If the panel is known to the town, Ruby saw it. The delta wants the panel known widely enough for Ally to find it and unknown to three people who saw Violet weekly. Could Ally see it before chapter 7? The moment she holds the letter and the second of the two witnesses, which the delta places in chapter 6 by its own account; the ordering is controllable but the delta has it a chapter early.

Severity. Fatal to the claim that chapter 7 turns on a fact. Serious to the chapter.

What would have to be true. The letter would have to claim, or the story would have to establish beyond a reader's doubt, that Violet's account of her own year was meant to be complete; "to show you what I mean" has to go. Rulings 2 and 7 would have to be re-cut so that they do not hand Violet an innocent reason for each omission. And one of "known to the town" or "only Brad and Margo" has to be struck, with the chain from Margo's file to Ally written out if the second survives.

Front 5. The first minute

Strongest objection. It is a summary. Every clause is retrospective and the last clause gives away the room's outcome. "She said she might be imagining it; she wasn't; she was dead" holds a past danger to a woman

already dead, and a coroner has already filed it as an accident. "Three weeks later they were sure it was one of them" is irony, and irony is a pleasure for a reader who already trusts you, not a hook for a listener who does not. The only concrete threat in the whole delta that is a present-tense image is the tin: tobacco stained through the paper, the lid loose, the bottle six inches. It is in section 2 and it is not in ruling 6. What the listener holds inside sixty seconds under ruling 6 is a sad idea, not a danger.

Severity. Serious, and testable before ruling, as the delta already intends.

What would have to be true. The three blind readers would have to report, unprompted, a danger they are holding at the end of sixty seconds, and name it. If they name the ashes or the padlock, the hook is the object, not the sentence. If they name nothing, ruling 6 has produced a summary.

Front 6. The new facts

Brad reads the debt book on Day 0. The sweep's "he cannot" is wrong for this man. A padlock can be shimmed or picked without damage in fourteen days by someone who forges a dead woman's cursive over one long day at her bench. That does not end the episode early; it moves the swap earlier and deletes the boat owner's dawn sighting, which is a clue the story wants. The competent action that does end it is the one the sweep omits: Brad took the book, and Margo knows by Day 8 that it is gone. See Front 3: Margo to Del, Day 8. Serious.

The ashes and the sister. The sister does not end it. The person who can is whoever walked the back bedroom on Day 0. Brad found her, or was there for the finding; he waited twenty minutes; ambulance and police attended a sudden death at home and the coroner was involved. Ruling 5 has him take the tube "that night," meaning the scatter tube was on the shelf while the house was attended. Any officer or paramedic who noted a crematorium scatter tube in the back bedroom on Day 0 contradicts a letter saying it went to the store on the ninth, and Del hears about the letter on Day 15. Serious. What would have to be true: the tube leaves the shelf in the twenty minutes before anyone arrives, and the delta must say so.

Liam's two boat requests. Brad is salting with a private exchange he was not present at, known to him only from Violet's side of it. He writes "he didn't ask why." Liam was there. On Day 14 Liam says "I did ask why; she said she wasn't ready; Ruby, I told you in March," and the room now holds a letter in Vi's hand with a false statement in it, which is a forgery, and chapter 7 arrives on Day 14. Serious. What would have to be true: Liam's memory matches the forgery in every particular and he told nobody at the time, and the delta asserts both without a line.

The forged police ban. Two objections. First, the ban is the forger's tell: a letter whose whole register is "I might be imagining it" contains one sentence with a will in it, and it is the sentence that keeps the police out. Any reader of chapter 2 will flag it as the anomaly, and Ruby the nurse should. Second, the sweep clears Ruby's Day 15 visit and Margo's Day 8 knowledge separately and never together. A missing financial record (Day 8) plus a dead woman's written belief in an intruder with her key (Day 15) reaching the same detective inside a week is enough for Del to ask who owed her. Serious. What would have to be true: Margo never mentions the book to anyone but the sister, and the sister never mentions it to Del.

"The ninth." The delta clears the four and nobody else. Clients, the café, deliveries, the sister she had just fought with, and the Day 0 attenders above are unplaced. Brad sets the date from the debt book; if her book of everything does not record visitors, he is guessing, and he would know he is guessing. Cosmetic if the date is fixed after the last visitor of any kind; serious until someone lists the visitors.

Verdict

REWORK. Confidence high. The single finding that drives it is chapter 7: the turn is an omission from a list the forged letter itself calls a starter list "to show you what I mean," and the delta's own rulings 2 and 7 give Violet an innocent, in-character reason for each of the two omissions, so what is offered as a contradiction between a document and the world is an argument Ally makes about Violet's character, the same kind of argument that convicted Liam. Behind it stand three serious faults that compound rather than sit apart: the best judge of a hand on the coast clearing the only other hand trained in her alphabet; Margo holding every element of her "reading," with the counter-document in her own file, by Day 19 and not acting until Day 51; and the Day 8 missing debt book, which the sweep never lists, reaching Del a week before the letter does. The internal contradictions (a loose lid in a forgery that cut the tin; debts "known to the town" in one ruling and known to two people in another) are drafting, but they sit exactly on the load-bearing joints, which suggests the seven rulings were accepted one at a time and never read against each other.